



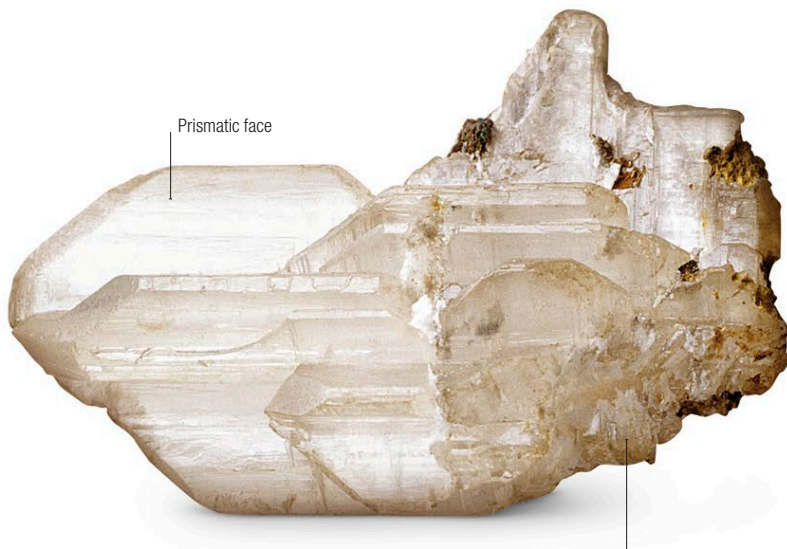
Cerussite

△ Group of cerussite crystals from Cumbria, UK

Cerussite has been known since antiquity and is named after the Latin *cerussa*, or white lead pigment. A lead carbonate, cerussite is the most common ore of lead after galena. It is generally colourless, but may be blue to green when copper impurities are present. Its refractive index is nearly as high as that of diamond, making its faceted stones especially brilliant. Unfortunately, such stones are rare; difficult to facet due to the gem's softness, brittleness, and tendency to break, they are also too soft to be worn.

Specification

Chemical name Lead carbonate | **Formula** PbCO_3
Colours White, blue to green | **Structure** Orthorhombic
Hardness 3–3.5 | **SG** 6.5 | **RI** 1.8–2.1 | **Lustre**
Adamantine to vitreous | **Streak** Colourless | **Locations**
Namibia, Morocco, Australia, USA



Prismatic gem crystal | Rough | This transparent, well-formed, prismatic single crystal of white cerussite consists of fine gem-quality material.



Cumbrian crystals | Rough | The county of Cumbria, in northern England, has produced cerussite since Roman times. This group of crystals is a fine example.



Twinned crystals | Rough | Cerussite is one of only a few minerals that produces star or cross-shaped twin crystals, such as in this excellent specimen.

Unusually long crystals of cerussite were found in the Pentire Glaze mine in Cornwall, UK



Faceted cerussite | Cut | Similar to rhodochrosite, cerussite is soft and extremely difficult to facet. Gems like this brilliant are rare and cut only for collectors.

Cerussite in cosmetics

The deadly beauty product

From around the 16th century, cerussite was widely used in cosmetic products designed to lighten the skin – a popular variety was known as “Venetian ceruse”. However, due to the the mineral’s lead content, such beauty treatments were also poisonous to the user. Symptoms included swelling of the eyes, changes to skin texture, and hair loss – perhaps related to this, by the 18th century it had become fashionable to shave the top of the hairline. In severe cases, lead poisoning could cause death.



Elizabeth I | The English queen was rumoured to be a user of the “Venetian ceruse” cosmetic.